> In the space of a few years, since 1985, when the Law of Associations was passed, and since 1987, when the Civil Code was passed, more than 2,000 associations and civil organizations were created, including the majority of those which function today as non-governmental organizations. These include a wide spectrum of cultural, scientific, sports, and environmental groups, etc.
>
> This pluralism represents a recognition that the diversity of Cuban society, which has always existed, cannot go on being expressed exclusively within the old mass organizations.[51]

Cuban intellectuals' analyses of politics in the United States and Cuba are important to understand in several respects. First, they present a nuanced view of the political system that U.S. analysts tend to promote as a universal ideal. It is clear that for many Cuban thinkers, multi-party democracy is only one form among many forms of democracy, and not necessarily the most attractive one. Second, reading Cuban authors' analyses of their own political system encourages U.S. audiences to acknowledge that Cuba's political system cannot be described simply and statically, as it generally is in U.S. political discourse, as a "dictatorship." Cuban citizens nominate candidates and vote in secret ballot elections; they participate in mass organizations; they participate in neighborhood, workplace, and municipal assemblies where real problems are discussed and debated, and decisions are made. What's more, the political system has evolved considerably over the course of the Revolution, and includes aspects that encourage and open spaces for political participation as well as aspects that discourage and close it off.

The discussions about democracy taking place in Cuba show that Cuban social scientists are not – as they are often portrayed abroad – merely regurgitators of an official, party-determined ideological line. Outsiders often assume that all domestic critics of Cuba's political system – especially those calling for greater democracy – are dissidents. But there exists a voice in Cuban intellectual life that seeks change from within, seeking to slowly open space for dialogue and debate by their own work.